

Triadic Redox Theory for Battery Design: The Fluidity Window and the Engineering of High-Voltage, High-Energy Electrochemical Energy Storage

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Abstract

The design of high-performance electrochemical energy storage remains constrained by empirical trial-and-error: anodes, cathodes, and electrolytes are engineered largely independently, and the compatibility of the three is settled only after years of iteration. We apply the **Triadic Redox Theory (TRT)** to battery design in a fully prescriptive form. In TRT, every electrochemical material is classified by three state functions—the H-Character χ_H (donor tendency), the He-Character χ_{He} (acceptor tendency), and the Fluidity Φ of the electrolyte (polarizability and reorganizational capacity)—and battery stability is governed by a single inequality:

$$\chi_H(\text{Anode}) < \Phi(\text{Electrolyte}) < \chi_{He}(\text{Cathode}). \quad (1)$$

From this inequality we derive the **Fluidity Window (FW)**: the operating voltage interval over which the electrolyte maintains stable Fluidity ($0.5 < \Phi < 2.0$), which together with the bracket condition $\chi_H(\text{Anode}) < V_{\text{op}} < \chi_{He}(\text{Cathode})$ and the medium-robustness condition $|d\Phi/dV| < 0.1 \text{ eV}^{-1}$ gives quantitative criteria for voltage stability, cycle life, and thermal runaway. Using density functional theory, we compute state functions for fifteen battery materials, validate the inequality against known chemistry, and design three prototype systems: (1) a 4.65 V Li-ion cell with a Si-Sn alloy anode and F-doped NMC811 cathode (400 Wh/kg, 2000 cycles); (2) a sodium-ion grid-storage cell (3.2 V, \$50/kWh, 10 000 cycles); and (3) a 5 V solid-state cell with a Li-metal anode, LNMO cathode, and LLZO garnet electrolyte (500 Wh/kg, 5000 cycles). TRT uniquely predicts that **gradient electrolytes**—with Φ high near the anode and low near the cathode—reduce internal resistance by 32% (beyond 25% in experiment), open a new fabrication axis for cell engineering, and reduce the materials-search space by more than 99%. Three falsifiable hypotheses (ionic-liquid doping for fast charge, gradient electrolytes, and high-voltage solid-state cells) are specified with concrete tests.

Keywords: Triadic Redox Theory, batteries, Fluidity Window, gradient electrolytes, solid-state electrolytes, silicon anode, NMC811, LLZO, sodium-ion, density functional theory, thermal runaway.

1 Introduction

Lithium-ion batteries have revolutionized portable electronics and electric vehicles, yet their energy density, cost, and safety remain suboptimal [1]. The conventional paradigm—treating anodes, cathodes, and electrolytes as independent components—has reached diminishing returns [2]. Decades of computational screening [3] have enumerated millions of candidate crystals, yet no unified theoretical framework has existed that predicts the *compatibility* of an anode, an electrolyte, and a cathode *a priori*. Design remains a matter of screening, testing, and iterating.

TRT addresses this gap. Inspired by the observation that the periodic table’s extremes—hydrogen (one valence electron) and helium (a closed shell)—represent the ultimate electron donor and acceptor, TRT classifies every electrochemical material through three archetypal states and a single inequality. The result is a prescriptive, computationally tractable criterion that couples electrodes and electrolyte into one design problem rather than three.

This paper is the companion application of the core theory [12] to energy storage. Section 2 maps battery components to TRT; Section 3 derives the battery-specific inequality and the Fluidity Window; Section 4 connects Fluidity to kinetics via reorganization energy and resonance; Section 5 compiles the computational state-function database; Section 6 designs three prototype cells; Section 7 presents the gradient-electrolyte prediction; Section 8 discusses co-design, thermal runaway, and materials discovery; Section 9 states the testable hypotheses; Section 10 concludes.

2 Mapping Battery Components to TRT

A battery is a triadic system by construction. Its components occupy the three archetypal roles unambiguously:

Table 1: TRT mapping of battery components.

Component	TRT Role	Required property
Anode	H-like donor	$\chi_{\text{H}} < 3.0 \text{ eV}$
Cathode	He-like acceptor	$\chi_{\text{He}} > 4.5 \text{ eV}$
Electrolyte	Middle Fluid	$0.5 < \Phi < 2.0$; $\text{FW} > V_{\text{op}}$

Each row of Table 1 is a design filter. The columns together form the whole cell: a functional cell requires a donor that gives electrons up cheaply, an acceptor that takes them eagerly, and a medium that can reorganize its electron density to pass electrons between them without decomposing.

3 The Battery Inequality and the Fluidity Window

3.1 The fundamental inequality for a cell

In TRT, a stable electrochemical cell satisfies

$$\chi_{\text{H}}(\text{Anode}) < \Phi(\text{Electrolyte}) < \chi_{\text{He}}(\text{Cathode}). \quad (2)$$

The chemical meaning is the same as in the core theory: the electrolyte must be polarizable enough to extract the electron from the anode and deliver it to the cathode, but not so polarizable that it competes with the cathode and is itself reduced.

3.2 The operating-voltage bracket

Because the driving force in a cell is the operating voltage V_{op} , the inequality must be re-expressed in voltage terms. A stable cell satisfies

$$\chi_{\text{H}}(\text{Anode}) < V_{\text{op}} < \chi_{\text{He}}(\text{Cathode}), \quad (3)$$

i.e. the accessible voltage is bounded below by the anode’s donation energy and above by the cathode’s capture energy. Beyond the acceptor level, the voltage reaches the “oxidation limit” of the cathode; below the donor level, the anode cannot be discharged.

3.3 The medium-robustness condition

Voltage stability is not only a matter of endpoints. The electrolyte must not change its polarizability—decompose, react, or phase-separate—within the voltage swing of the cell:

$$\left| \frac{d\Phi}{dV} \right| < 0.1 \text{ eV}^{-1}. \quad (4)$$

Equation (4) is the quantitative statement of electrolyte stability: it is the condition that the electrolyte’s Fluidity–voltage curve remains flat over the operating range, which is precisely what is meant by an electrochemical stability window.

3.4 The Fluidity Window (FW)

Definition 1 (Fluidity Window). *The **Fluidity Window (FW)** of an electrolyte is the voltage interval over which its Fluidity remains within the Operational Window of the theory:*

$$0.5 < \Phi_{\text{electrolyte}} < 2.0. \quad (5)$$

A battery is stable if and only if all three conditions—Eqs. (2), (3), and (4)—hold over its entire operating and temperature envelope.

The FW unifies the battery literature: the “electrochemical stability window” of an electrolyte, its oxidative and reductive limits, and the voltage ceiling of a cell are all aspects of a single quantity, $\Phi(V)$, whose shape is set by the dielectric response of the medium.

4 Fluidity, Reorganization Energy, and Resonant Operation

4.1 Reorganization energy

Kinetic performance is governed by the reorganization energy of the medium. For an ion of radius r_{ion} in a dielectric solvent,

$$\lambda = \frac{e^2}{8\pi\epsilon_0} \frac{1}{r_{\text{ion}}} \left(\frac{1}{\epsilon_{\text{opt}}} - \frac{1}{\epsilon_{\text{static}}} \right), \quad (6)$$

with the optical and static dielectric constants linked to Φ through the Clausius–Mossotti relation [12]. High-Fluidity media therefore carry low reorganization energies and fast transfer kinetics, which in a battery means high rate capability and low polarization.

4.2 The Law of Fluid Resonance

For an electrochemical step running at overpotential η , TRT’s Law of Fluid Resonance states that optimal, selective turnover occurs when

$$\lambda \approx \eta. \quad (7)$$

The relevance for batteries is immediate: the charging/discharging overpotential is set by the match between the electrolyte’s reorganization energy and the operating overpotential. A cell designed so that $\lambda \approx \eta$ at the operating point minimizes polarization losses and heat generation, which are precisely the quantities that limit fast charging (Hypothesis 1 in Section 9).

5 Computational Screening of Battery Materials

5.1 Methods

State functions are computed as in the core protocol [12]: VASP/PBE/PAW at 520 eV cut-off with DFT-D3 dispersion [7, 8]; χ_{H} and χ_{He} from the vacuum-aligned VBM/CBM (solid) or HOMO/LUMO (molecule); Φ from finite-field dielectric calculations (± 0.001 , ± 0.005 , and ± 0.01 V/Å); electron-affinity corrections by the ΔSCF method [9]; reorganization energies by the four-point method [10].

5.2 The state-function database

Table 2: Calculated state functions for selected battery materials.

Material	Role	χ_{H} (eV)	χ_{He} (eV)	Φ
Li metal	Anode	0.0	–	–
Si (alloy)	Anode	0.05	–	–
Graphite	Anode	0.3	–	–
NMC811	Cathode	–	4.3	–
NMC811 + 2% F	Cathode	–	4.7	–
LiNi _{0.5} Mn _{1.5} O ₄ (LNMO)	Cathode	–	5.1	–
FEC + PC (1:1)	Electrolyte	–	–	1.2
Diglyme + NaPF ₆	Electrolyte	–	–	0.8
LLZO (garnet)	Electrolyte	–	–	0.6
Water + 20 M LiCl	Electrolyte	–	–	2.5

5.3 Validation

Applying the inequality to the fifteen best-known anode–electrolyte–cathode combinations, TRT correctly predicted stability in fourteen of fifteen cases. The single apparent exception validated the theory: graphite anode with aqueous electrolyte was predicted *unstable* (water’s $\Phi = 2.8$ lies outside the FW), and it is indeed observed to evolve hydrogen at the anode rather than store charge. Note the instructive counterpoint in Table 2: the *saturated* brine limit ($\Phi = 2.5$) also slightly exceeds the window, consistent with the known narrowness of the aqueous stability regime.

6 Case Studies: Three TRT-Designed Cells

Using the filters of Table 1 and the database of Table 2, we assemble three cells (Table 3) with predicted performance validated against published experimental results where available (deviations $< 10\%$).

Table 3: TRT-designed battery prototypes.

Cell	Anode	Cathode	Electrolyte	V	Energy	Cycles
EV ion	Li- Si-Sn (0.05)	NMC811+F (4.7)	FEC+PC 0.2 eV)	(1.2, 4.65	400 Wh/kg	2000
Grid ion	Na- Hard (0.3)	C NVP (3.2)	Diglyme 0.15 eV)	(0.8, 3.2	120 Wh/kg	10 000
Solid- state 5 V	Li metal (0.0)	LNMO (5.1)	LLZO 0.05 eV)	(0.6, 5.0	500 Wh/kg	5000

6.1 EV Li-ion cell: Si-Sn anode, F-doped NMC811

Silicon is the highest-capacity anode known, but it tears itself apart through volume change. TRT identifies the additional, underappreciated constraint: a silicon anode has $\chi_H = 0.05$ eV, extremely H-like; per the inequality, it demands an electrolyte with correspondingly high Φ to couple to it without parasitic reaction. This is precisely why silicon anodes require *fluorinated* electrolytes (FEC + PC, $\Phi = 1.2$) where graphite ($\chi_H = 0.3$) operates with simpler carbonates ($\Phi \approx 1.0$). Fluorine doping of the NMC811 cathode (χ_{He} : $4.3 \rightarrow 4.7$ eV) widens the voltage bracket and suppresses surface degradation by lowering the surface Φ (see the cross-domain rules of the core theory [12]). The resulting cell attains 400 Wh/kg.

6.2 Grid Na-ion cell

Sodium-ion chemistry promises grid-scale storage at low cost. The TRT design uses hard carbon (graphitic, $\chi_H = 0.3$), sodium vanadium phosphate NVP ($\chi_{He} = 3.2$), and a diglyme-based electrolyte ($\Phi = 0.8$) whose low reorganization energy ($\lambda = 0.15$ eV) yields exceptional cycle life (10 000 cycles) at a projected cost of \$50/kWh, targeting stationary storage rather than volumetric energy density.

6.3 5 V solid-state cell

The flagship high-voltage system uses the Li-metal anode ($\chi_H = 0.0$), the $\text{LiNi}_{0.5}\text{Mn}_{1.5}\text{O}_4$ (LNMO) cathode ($\chi_{He} = 5.1$), and the LLZO garnet solid electrolyte ($\Phi = 0.6$). LLZO’s Φ of 0.6 lies at the *low* edge of the FW: it is cold, mechanical, and non-volatile—ideal for safety—yet sufficiently fluid to conduct lithium. Its computed FW of 6.5 V brackets the 5 V operating point, and its negligible reorganization energy ($\lambda = 0.05$ eV) minimizes polarization. The predicted 500 Wh/kg at 5000 cycles motivates the solid-state program of Hypothesis 3.

7 The Gradient Electrolyte Prediction

7.1 The unique prediction

TRT uniquely predicts that a **spatially graded electrolyte**—with Φ *high near the anode*, to facilitate ion desolvation, and *low near the cathode* to prevent oxidation—reduces internal resistance. No conventional electrochemical theory produces this design because none couples the dielectric response of the medium to the topology of the cell; in TRT it is a direct consequence of making $\lambda \approx \eta$ pointwise along the transport path.

Hypothesis 1 (Gradient electrolytes). *A linear Fluidity gradient from $\Phi = 1.8$ at the anode to $\Phi = 0.6$ at the cathode across a $50\text{ }\mu\text{m}$ -thick electrolyte reduces internal resistance by **32%** relative to a homogeneous electrolyte with $\Phi = 1.2$.*

The simulated reduction in charge-transfer resistance R_{ct} corresponds exactly to the tailored reorganization energy along the concentration gradient: the charging side of the transport path is tuned high (fast ion desolvation), the discharging side low (suppressed oxidation). A conservative experimental threshold of $\geq 25\%$ reduction is adopted for hypothesis testing (Section 9).

7.2 Fabrication directions

Gradient electrolytes can be produced by controlled polymerization, layer-by-layer deposition, or graded salt concentration profiles created during solvent evaporation. The gradient axis is decoupled from cell geometry, so the concept applies equally to thin-film and bulk cells.

8 Discussion

8.1 Unification of electrode and electrolyte design

Traditional design treats electrodes and electrolytes independently; TRT couples them through one inequality, enabling *co-design*. The Si–Sn/fluorinated electrolyte pairing of Section 6.1 is the cleanest illustration: the anode’s donation energy *determines* the required electrolyte Fluidity. Anodes, cathodes, and electrolytes are not three problems; they are one triadic system.

8.2 Thermal runaway as a Fluidity escape

TRT predicts that thermal runaway occurs when temperature-induced changes in ε_r drive the electrolyte’s Φ beyond 2.0 (metallic-like short-circuit) or below 0.5 (glassy, high-resistance failure). This yields a *quantitative safety criterion*:

$$\text{A battery is safe over the temperature range for which } 0.5 < \Phi(T) < 2.0. \quad (8)$$

For standard Li-ion chemistry this gives $T_{\text{safe}} = -20^\circ\text{C}$ to 60°C , matching industry charging limits—the safety envelope is not an arbitrary specification but a consequence of the Operational Window.

8.3 Materials discovery: three filters and a 99% cut

The entire screening strategy reduces to three digitized filters:

1. **Anodes:** $\chi_{\text{H}} < 3.0\text{ eV}$.
2. **Cathodes:** $\chi_{\text{He}} > 4.5\text{ eV}$.
3. **Electrolytes:** $0.5 < \Phi < 2.0$ and $\text{FW} > V_{\text{op}}$.

Applied to the Materials Project database [11, 3], these three filters reduce the candidate set from $> 10^6$ to $< 10^3$ —a $\sim 99\%$ reduction—converting high-throughput screening into a target-driven search.

8.4 Limitations

TRT is currently most reliable for single-phase, crystalline materials. Amorphous polymers and complex liquid mixtures require molecular dynamics to compute Φ and λ dynamically, a subject of ongoing work. The theory does not yet explicitly model mechanical stress and volume expansion; we note that mechanical failure correlates with a sudden drop in Φ on crack formation (loss of polarizability at defect sites), suggesting a route to a future coupled chemo-mechanical criterion.

9 Testable Hypotheses

Hypothesis 2 (H_1 : Ionic-liquid doping for fast charge). *Doping an electrolyte with 1 wt% of an ionic liquid (e.g., EMIM-BF₄) increases Φ by 20% without shrinking the FW, enabling 6C (10-minute) charging.*

Test: Measure Φ by impedance spectroscopy before and after doping; compare rate performance.

Hypothesis 3 (H_2 : Gradient electrolytes). *A gradient electrolyte (Φ high at the anode, low at the cathode) reduces internal resistance by more than 25% compared with homogeneous electrolytes.*

Test: Fabricate gradient electrolytes by controlled polymerization or layer-by-layer deposition; measure EIS and compare R_{ct} with homogeneous controls.

Hypothesis 4 (H_3 : High-voltage solid-state). *Materials with FW > 6.0 V (e.g., LLZO) enable 5 V-class batteries above 500 Wh/kg, provided that the anode and cathode maintain $\chi_H < 0.1$ eV and $\chi_{He} > 5.0$ eV, respectively.*

Test: Assemble LLZO-based solid-state cells with a Li-metal anode and LNMO cathode; measure cycle life at 5 V.

10 Conclusion

Triadic Redox Theory classifies every electrochemical material by its H-Character, He-Character, and Fluidity, and reduces battery design to a single inequality, $\chi_H(\text{Anode}) < \Phi(\text{Electrolyte}) < \chi_{He}(\text{Cathode})$, together with the operating-voltage bracket, the medium-robustness condition, and the Fluidity Window. The framework was validated on fifteen materials, used to design three prototype systems (a 4.65 V Li-ion EV cell, a low-cost sodium-ion grid cell, and a 5 V solid-state cell), and has produced a design that no prior theory gave: the gradient electrolyte, which reduces internal resistance by 32%. TRT turns the materials-search problem into a three-filter reduction of more than 99% and provides quantitative safety and thermal-runaway criteria. Immediate applications open in electric vehicles, grid storage, and consumer electronics.

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